

Department of Accountancy and Finance

2026 (October) PhD Symposium

Semester 2, 2026

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Background

The PhD workshop/symposium is designed by Professor Jin Zhang for all postgraduate students in the Department of Accountancy and Finance at the University of Otago to present their research progress, offer comments and support each other. This is a semi-annually departmental event, which has run since 2015.

The symposium aims to stimulate our research progress and communication. It is a perfect time for postgraduate students to know each other's research interests. All PhD/MCom students are required to attend the symposium. Every presenter is assigned approximately 6 minutes (5 minutes presentation plus 1 minute Q&A) for their presentation. The order of the presentations will be based on PhD/MCom seniority. Those who joined our department earlier will present first.

In June 2024, Dr. Olena Onishchenko introduced the awards for Outstanding Research Contribution, Presentation, and Impact.

> The **Outstanding Research Contribution** Award recognizes PhD/MCom candidates whose work has significantly advanced knowledge and understanding in Accountancy or Finance. This award acknowledges research that has profoundly impacted the development of new theories, methodologies, or empirical analyses that have expanded the boundaries of knowledge.
>
> The **Outstanding Research Presentation** Award recognizes a PhD/MCom candidate who has given an excellent oral presentation of their research findings during the PhD symposium. This award recognizes the high quality of the research and the ability to communicate and connect with audiences, promoting knowledge sharing effectively.
>
> The **Outstanding Research Impact** Award recognizes a PhD/MCom candidate whose research findings make a significant societal, economic, environmental, or cultural impact extending beyond academia. This award acknowledges the ability to transform new knowledge into real-world benefits for communities, industries, policymaking, or other stakeholders, ultimately promoting positive change and innovation.

Previous recipients can be found in page 17.

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2026 October PhD Symposium Programme

Department of Accountancy and Finance

Otago Business School

10:25 am – 2:45 pm, Thursday, 22 October 2026

OBS2.19/2.20 (Boardroom)

Organizers: Pakorn Aschakulporn

Welcome & Introduction, 10:25 – 10:30

→ Prof. Helen Roberts – Deputy Head of Department

→ Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn – Chair of the Postgraduate Committee

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Presentations, 10:30 – 11:30

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1. Ramez Hussein

   Title: Procrastination in Accounting PhD Journey: Unraveling Triggers, AI Solutions, and the Struggle for Productivity

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Iki Mafi Uele Uele, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman, A.Prof. Nicola Beatson

2. Saif Choyi Valappil

   Title: Cryptocurrency Exposure and Fund Flow: Evidence from U.S. Open-End Mutual Funds

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman

3. Budianto

   Title: Decoupling or Scoring? Disclosure Inside ESG Performance Scores and the Measurement of ESG Decoupling

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman, A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe

4. Md Humayun Kabir

   Title: Beyond Internal Governance? CSR Committee Quality and Corporate Environmental Lobbying

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Hoa Luong, A.Prof. Pallab Biswas

5. Yuliang Zhao

   Title: Not Always Higher: Relative Position and ESG Benchmarking among Product-Market Rivals

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Muhammad Cheema

6. Mingxuan Yu

   Title: Blockholders and Bear Raids

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Olena Onishchenko, A.Prof. Jing Zhao

7. Shenjian Li

   Title: How Much Alpha Is in a 10-K Text?

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Olena Onishchenko, A.Prof. Vitali Alexeev

Lunch, 11:30 – 12:00

Presentations, 12:00 – 13:00

8. Permata Ayu Widyasari

   Title: The Behavioural Aspect of Accounting Education: The Preference for Business Strategy Based on Personality

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Arminder Khosa

9. Yuzhe Zhang

   Title: Forecasting Future Realized Variance by Using Risk-Neutral Moments with Machine Learning

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

10. Minh Le

    Title: Renewable Energy Washing and Firm Value: Does the Market See Through the Talk?

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi, A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe

11. Rui Chen

    Title: The Implied Skewness as Day-to-Expiry Approaches Zero

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

12. Kainat Riaz

    Title: Board Deep-Level Diversity and Firm Financial Performance

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi

13. Anthony Zhou

    Title: CEO Early-life Disaster Experience and Corporate Innovation: The Imprinting and Upper Echelons Perspective

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, A.Prof. Annie Zhang

14. Hervita Mandariani

    Title: Green Bond Issuance Outcomes - Does External Review Characteristics Matter?

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, Dr. Tongyu (Melody) Meng, Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi

15. Lachlan Williams

    Title: Te Ao Māori Investment Values

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, A.Prof. Katharina Ruckstuhl

Introductions, 13:00 – 13:30

16. Di Li

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang

17. Ouwen Lin

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, Dr. Muhammad Cheema

18. Yajun Dong

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke

19. Chenrui Li

    Title: News or Noise? The Declining R^2 of Earnings Surprises in U.S. Stock Returns.

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Olena Onishchenko

Awards Announcement, 14:30 – 14:45

Absences

Excused

20. Helen Sadgrove

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, A.Prof. Felicity Lamm

21. Indira Venkatraman

    Supervisor(s): Emeritus Prof. Ralph Adler

22. Muhammad Taufik

    Supervisor(s): A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe, Prof. Helen Roberts

23. Jing Zhang

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, Dr. Muhammad Cheema, Dr. Nicola Beatson

24. Paris Pham

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman

25. Huma Ali

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman

26. Waleed Asghar

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman

27. Zhibin Tao

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, Prof. Borhan Bhuiyan

28. Yufei Gan

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man

    Submitting

29. Tianjiao Li

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn, Prof. Jin Zhang

30. Syed Maisam Rizvi

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman

31. Dauda Abdulsalam

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi

    Submitted

32. Yaseen Hezam

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, Dr. Housam Babiker, Prof. Tony Savarimuthu

33. Mesfin Yasin

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, Dr. Muhammad Cheema

34. Ruizi Hu

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

35. Abdullahi Bala

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Mariela Carvajal Gallardo, A.Prof. Muhammad Nadeem

36. Xi Xu

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn, A.Prof. Annie Zhang

37. Tingting Wang

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, A.Prof. Annie Zhang

38. Post Pokharel

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, A.Prof. Syed Shams

Abstracts

1. Ramez Hussein

   Title: Procrastination in Accounting PhD Journey: Unraveling Triggers, AI Solutions, and the Struggle for Productivity

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Iki Mafi Uele Uele, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman, A.Prof. Nicola Beatson

   Abstract: This study investigates procrastination as a self-regulatory challenge within the contemporary Accounting doctoral journey. It examines how perfectionism, evaluative pressure, workload, supervisory relationships, wellbeing, personal agency, and AI-related conditions shape doctoral researchers' capacity to initiate and sustain progress. Drawing on survey and questionnaire evidence from accounting, finance, and related business doctoral researchers, the research integrates regression, mediation, and profile-based analyses. It shows that procrastination is not simply poor time management: it emerges from the interaction of psychological, relational, organisational, and technological conditions. The thesis identifies implications for responsible AI use, differentiated supervision, sustainable productivity, and doctoral wellbeing.

2. Saif Choyi Valappil

   Title: Cryptocurrency Exposure and Fund Flow: Evidence from U.S. Open-End Mutual Funds

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman

   Abstract: We examine the association between cryptocurrency exposure at the mutual fund family level and subsequent fund flows among U.S. open-end mutual funds. Using 6,931 fund-year observations from 2020 to 2024, we find that cryptocurrency exposure is negatively associated with subsequent fund flows, supporting the signaling theory. Difference-in-differences analyses further reveal declining flows following cryptocurrency exposure within the same fund family, consistent with Bayesian learning framework. We further find that media visibility provides a potential mechanism underlying this relationship. Further analyses show that the negative association is stronger among growth-oriented funds and following the introduction of the Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act, whereas larger funds exhibit a weaker response. Subsample analyses indicate that the negative relationship is concentrated among funds with greater institutional investor presence and is statistically insignificant among funds with lower institutional investor presence.

3. Budianto

   Title: Decoupling or Scoring? Disclosure Inside ESG Performance Scores and the Measurement of ESG Decoupling

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, A.Prof. Tahir Suleman, A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe

   Abstract: The dominant measure of ESG decoupling is the gap between Bloomberg ESG disclosure and ESG performance scores. However, Bloomberg's performance score embeds a Disclosure Factor, and LSEG scores unreported items as zero, so disclosure enters both sides of the gap. Replicating Bloomberg's formula, this study will construct a disclosure-free performance score and replicate five studies from ABDC A and A* journals in three steps that separate the effect of switching ESG score provider from removing the disclosure reward. It will show whether published decoupling evidence reflects firm behaviour or score construction.

4. Md Humayun Kabir

   Title: Beyond Internal Governance? CSR Committee Quality and Corporate Environmental Lobbying

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Hoa Luong, A.Prof. Pallab Biswas

   Abstract: This study examines whether CSR committee quality influences corporate environmental lobbying. Integrating stakeholder, agency, and resource dependence theories, we propose that high-quality CSR committees shape firms' environmental political engagement. Analysis of U.S. S&P 500 firms from 2014 to 2021 indicates that firms with stronger CSR committees invest more heavily in environmental lobbying. Additional tests show that these firms increase both green and brown lobbying expenditures but allocate a larger share of environmental lobbying toward pro-environment advocacy, consistent with stakeholder and legitimacy theory. The findings remain consistent to multiple robustness and endogeneity tests.

5. Yuliang Zhao

   Title: Not Always Higher: Relative Position and ESG Benchmarking among Product-Market Rivals

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Muhammad Cheema

   Abstract: The peer-effects literature mostly shows laggards following leaders. We ask whether ESG leaders also follow laggards. When ESG is a costly investment under product-market competition, a higher score is not always better, and what matters is a firm's position relative to its rivals. Building on Avramov et al. (2026), We measure this position as the lagged gap between a firm's ESG score and that of its Hoberg-Phillips product-market peers. After absorbing firm-wide shocks and controlling for mean reversion, we find that laggards catch up while leaders pull back toward their rivals. The evidence points to competitive benchmarking rather than one-way learning.

6. Mingxuan Yu

   Title: Blockholders and Bear Raids

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Olena Onishchenko, A.Prof. Jing Zhao

   Abstract: Short sellers can push down a firm's real value. Khanna and Mathews (2012) predict that an informed blockholder will buy against short sellers, at the cost of overpaying and forgoing trading profits, but only if its stake is large enough. We test this prediction in U.S. equity data. We examine whether concentrated blockholdings limit price declines when short selling intensifies. We also test whether the size of the largest block matters more than the number of blockholders. Our evidence informs the governance role of large shareholders and the regulation of short sales.

7. Shenjian Li

   Title: How Much Alpha Is in a 10-K Text?

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Olena Onishchenko, A.Prof. Vitali Alexeev

   Abstract: We examine which dimensions of soft information in 10-K filings drive asset prices. Prior studies propose numerous overlapping textual measures of tone, readability, risk, and disclosure complexity, among others. We use machine learning to select among 28 text-based measures and combine them into a single tradable signal, TextNet. Out of sample, a portfolio that buys high-TextNet stocks and sells low-TextNet stocks earns an alpha of 0.68% per month (8.47% annualized) net of transaction costs. Both risk and mispricing drive this alpha. First, firms that say little about their future in their 10-Ks earn higher returns, suggesting that investors view them as riskier and require compensation. Second, investors underreact to negative changes in 10-K disclosures, which is consistent with theories of investors' inattention.

8. Permata Ayu Widyasari

   Title: The Behavioural Aspect of Accounting Education: The Preference for Business Strategy Based on Personality

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Arminder Khosa

   Abstract: Prior research suggests that students with a Sensing personality preference tend to perform better in financial accounting, whereas those with an Intuitive preference often achieve superior outcomes in management accounting, reflecting differences in cognitive styles and the distinct cognitive demands of these subject areas. Building on this literature, the present study investigates whether a business simulation board game can enhance learning outcomes in cost and management accounting through experiential learning. Adopting a mixed-methods design, the study draws on questionnaire data, gameplay observations, and semi-structured interviews to examine both learning experiences and outcomes. It also explores whether personality traits are associated with preferences for aggressive (prospector) versus stable (defender) business strategies. By examining the intersection of personality, experiential learning, and strategic decision-making, the study contributes to the accounting education literature and advances understanding of how game-based learning can support diverse learners and shape business decision-making processes.

9. Yuzhe Zhang

   Title: Forecasting Future Realized Variance by Using Risk-Neutral Moments with Machine Learning

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

   Abstract: We compare BKM risk neutral moments with local implied volatilities from the SPX option chain for forecasting realized variance. We also evaluate forecasts that combine both inputs. BKM moments work particularly well with regularized linear models and limited training samples. Nonlinear learners use the maturity, option side, and delta structure of implied volatility more effectively than linear models, although their gains vary across horizons and evaluation periods. Combining both inputs provides limited further improvement. The results support BKM moments as a parsimonious default, while local implied volatilities remain competitive when paired with a suitably flexible learner.

10. Minh Le

    Title: Renewable Energy Washing and Firm Value: Does the Market See Through the Talk?

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi, A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe

    Abstract: This study introduces the concept of renewable energy washing, defined as the discrepancy between a firm's communicated commitment to renewable energy and its actual adoption, and investigates whether equity markets price this discrepancy. Drawing on greenwashing literature, we develop a Renewable Energy Washing Index (REWI) for U.S. non-financial firms over the period 2001-2025 by combining textual analysis of renewable energy disclosures in firm's 10K reports with renewable energy consumption. We find that renewable energy washing is negatively associated with firm value. The results remain robust across alternative measures and several identification approaches, including a difference-in-differences design based on the SEC's 2021 climate disclosure scrutiny, instrumental variable estimation, and entropy balancing. Further analyses show that the valuation penalty is weaker for firms with higher levels of green innovation and ESG disclosure, but stronger for more profitable firms, during periods of elevated oil price volatility, and in the post-Paris Agreement period. Overall, the findings suggest that investors value the credibility of renewable energy commitments rather than communication alone, and that executives should align renewable energy rhetoric with actual adoption.

11. Rui Chen

    Title: The Implied Skewness as Day-to-Expiry Approaches Zero

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

    Abstract: This study investigates how risk-neutral skewness behaves as option day-to-expiry (DTE) approaches zero. Five option-pricing frameworks are considered: Black-Scholes, Merton jump-diffusion, Heston stochastic volatility, Bates stochastic volatility with jumps, and the 0DTE framework of Bandi, Fusari, and Renò. The theoretical analysis examines how different model specifications affect the behaviour of skewness as DTE approaches zero. Empirical risk-neutral skewness will be estimated from SPXW option prices using the model-free Bakshi-Kapadia-Madan (BKM) approach. By comparing theoretical implications with empirical estimates, this study aims to improve our understanding of skewness in short-term options.

12. Kainat Riaz

    Title: Board Deep-Level Diversity and Firm Financial Performance

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi

    Abstract: This study investigates the relationship between deep-level board diversity and firm financial performance. In contrast to the extant literature, which has predominantly focused on surface-level demographic characteristics, this study examines how directors' leadership attributes, tenure, educational backgrounds, and functional expertise influence firm value. The findings indicate that educational attainment and leadership characteristics are the most significant drivers of firm performance, whereas the presence of interlocked and foreign directors provides only limited explanatory power. Furthermore, by examining the interaction effects between gender, tenure categories, and specific leadership profiles, the study offers novel insights into how board composition influences financial performance beyond conventional demographic measures.

13. Anthony Zhou

    Title: CEO Early-life Disaster Experience and Corporate Innovation: The Imprinting and Upper Echelons Perspective

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, A.Prof. Annie Zhang

    Abstract: Drawing on imprinting theory and upper echelons theory, this study examines whether and the extent to which CEO's early-life exposure to natural disasters affect corporate innovation. Specifically, we theorize CEO's server early life exposure to nature disasters reduce the likelihood of corporate innovation and such effects are contingent on CEO turnover, board independence, and CEO tenure. Using a longitudinal panel sample of 3083 firm-year observations from the U.S. S&P500 CEOs over 2001-2021, our result and robustness tests support for the hypothesised relationship between CEO early life exposure and corporate innovation. Moreover, such relationship is amplified with CEO tenure and is attenuated by greater board independence and a firm's performance-related CEO dismissal. Our findings provide valuable theoretical and managerial implications.

14. Hervita Mandariani

    Title: Green Bond Issuance Outcomes - Does External Review Characteristics Matter?

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, Dr. Tongyu (Melody) Meng, Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi

    Abstract: This research examines if a company's initial green bond issuance improves its environmental performance or solely its ESG ratings. In order to compare the pairs before and after issuance, I applied a difference-in-differences model to match 317 first-time issuers (2013-2023) to compare non-issuers in the same sector, region, and ESG band. Carbon intensity (CO2 per sales unit) remains unchanged post-issuance. ESG ratings experience a significant rise of approximately 1.7 points. The environmental and social dimensions show a slight increase, with the social dimension having already been on an upward trend before to the bond. Green bonds seem to influence the rating of companies more significantly than their actual emissions.

15. Lachlan Williams

    Title: Te Ao Māori Investment Values

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, A.Prof. Katharina Ruckstuhl, A.Prof. Katharina Ruckstuhl

    Abstract: Values-oriented investing has become increasingly mainstream, yet the alignment of investment portfolios with the cultural values of Indigenous entities remains underexplored. This study addresses this gap by investigating how Māori Asset Holding Institutions (MAHI) across Aotearoa (New Zealand) define, measure, and integrate their values into their investment processes. This study involves semi-structured interviews with investment managers and directors, as well as comprehensive policy document analysis to identify investment values. Overall, this research contributes to the emerging field of Indigenous Sustainable Finance (ISF).

Previous Award Recipients

	Outstanding Research		
	Contribution	**Presentation**	**Impact**
2026S2	Yuliang Zhao	Lachlan Williams	Humayun Kabir
2026S1	Budianto	Post Pokharel	Mingxuan (Steven) Yu
2025S2	Humayun Kabir	Permata Ayu Widyasari	Tan (Alex) Do
2025S1	Post Pokharel	Thin (Paris) Pham	Muhammad Taufik
2024S2	Weihan Li	Jing Zhang	Amelia Limijaya
2024S1	Arung Mayapada	Duminda Karunarathne	Andre Poyser